Formal Verification of Alternative Mathematical Frameworks: A Case Study Using Lean 4

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Abstract. We present a systematic protocol for applying interactive theorem provers to claims originating from alternative or non-standard mathematical frameworks. Using Lean 4 [13] and mathlib [14], we extract formalizable assertions from such sources, translate them into dependent type theory, and attempt proof or disproof—reporting results without prejudice. We demonstrate the protocol through a case study on Eric Dollard's "versor algebra," a non-standard extension of electrical engineering mathematics. Results are deliberately mixed: we verify a $\mathbb{Z}_4$ cyclic group structure (trivially correct), disprove a claimed versor-form equivalence (sign error), establish by algebraic necessity that the proposed operators collapse to standard 4th roots of unity, and formalize four Clifford algebras—$\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$, $\mathrm{Cl}(3,0)$, $\mathrm{Cl}(1,3)$—each independently verified. We propose a five-category taxonomy for classifying claims from alternative frameworks: Verified, Disproved, Algebraic Necessity, Ambiguous, and Unfalsifiable. To our knowledge, this represents the first application of interactive theorem provers to formalize claims from non-mainstream mathematical sources.

Keywords: formal verification · Lean 4 · alternative mathematics · Clifford algebras · versor algebra

1 Introduction

Interactive theorem provers have verified some of mathematics' most challenging results: Hales' Kepler conjecture via the Flyspeck project [1], the Four Color Theorem [2], Scholze's liquid tensor experiment [3], the polynomial Freiman-Ruzsa conjecture [4], and the consistency of Quine's New Foundations [5]. In each case, the target was mainstream mathematics—contested, complex, or uncertain, but arising within accepted mathematical frameworks.

A conspicuous gap remains: no prior work applies interactive theorem provers to claims from *alternative* or *non-standard* mathematical frameworks. By "alternative framework" we mean a coherent system of mathematical claims originating outside peer-reviewed mathematics, typically from independent researchers, that proposes non-standard definitions, operations, or equivalences. Such frameworks are distinct from non-standard *foundations* (e.g., HoTT, constructive

mathematics), which are rigorous alternative approaches proposed within the mathematical community [6].

This gap is structural, not accidental. Four factors conspire to maintain it:

1. **Cultural separation.** Formal verification and alternative mathematics communities have zero overlap.
2. **No academic incentive.** Formalizing alternative claims yields no new theorems and no library contributions, while risking the appearance of legitimizing pseudoscience.
3. **Asymmetric difficulty.** Translating informal non-standard claims into dependent type theory requires both mathematical expertise and judgment about ambiguous notation.
4. **No client.** Proponents of alternative frameworks rarely seek formal verification (which might disprove claims), and mainstream mathematicians see no need (they already reject such claims on conventional grounds).

This gap is a missed opportunity. Formal verification of alternative frameworks is methodologically interesting precisely when it produces *mixed* results: some claims verified, others disproved, still others classified as ambiguous or unfalsifiable. Pure debunking is uninteresting (it offers no methodological contribution), and pure verification is unlikely for frameworks that diverge from standard mathematics. Mixed results show that formal methods discriminate, and they reveal genuine mathematical structure worth analyzing.

Contributions. This paper makes four contributions:

1. A six-step *protocol* for extracting, translating, and verifying claims from alternative mathematical frameworks (Section 3).
2. A *case study* applying the protocol to Eric Dollard's versor algebra, producing over 200 formally verified declarations across 8 Lean 4 proof files with zero `sorry` gaps (Section 4).
3. A five-category *taxonomy* for classifying claims from alternative frameworks: Verified, Disproved, Algebraic Necessity, Ambiguous, and Unfalsifiable (Section 5).
4. Four independently formalized *Clifford algebras*—$\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$, $\mathrm{Cl}(3,0)$, $\mathrm{Cl}(1,3)$—demonstrating that formal methods can suggest corrections, not merely judge (Section 6).

2 Related Work

2.1 Formalization of Contested Mathematics

The closest parallels to our work involve formalizations where the mathematical community itself had doubts about correctness. The Flyspeck project [1] verified Hales' proof of the Kepler conjecture after referees could not fully evaluate it. The liquid tensor experiment [3] verified a theorem where even the author (Scholze) had reservations. Wilshaw's formalization of NF consistency [5] addressed a proof that mainstream reviewers could not confidently evaluate. In each case, the target was contested-within-mainstream, not alternative/fringe.

2.2 Formalization of Physical Theories

Tooby-Smith's PhysLean/HepLean project [7] digitalizes mainstream physics in Lean 4, from classical mechanics through quantum field theory. Bobbin et al. [8] formalized Langmuir and BET adsorption theories, demonstrating that Lean catches faulty logic and reveals hidden assumptions—the closest methodological parallel to our work, though applied to mainstream physical chemistry.

2.3 Historical Mathematics Formalization

Fleuriot [9] formalized Newton's geometric proofs in Isabelle/HOL and discovered a flaw in one of Newton's proofs. This is the closest near-miss to our work: a proof assistant applied to historical non-rigorous reasoning that finds errors. The distinction is that Newton is mainstream; the "non-standard" aspect is proof style, not framework.

2.4 Clifford Algebra Formalization

Wieser and Song [10] formalized Clifford algebras in Lean 3/mathlib, providing the mathematical objects that overlap with our case study. Their work formalizes standard theory; ours applies it to non-standard claims.

2.5 Philosophy of Formal Verification

Avigad [11] examines how formal verification contributes to mathematical understanding. Imbert and Ardourel [12] analyze formal verification's epistemological role in computational science. Shulman [6] discusses proof assistants for exploring alternative foundations (HoTT), though these are rigorous alternatives proposed by credentialed mathematicians.

3 The Protocol

We propose a six-step protocol for applying interactive theorem provers to alternative mathematical frameworks. The individual techniques at each step are standard; the contribution is the systematic application to a novel domain.

1. **Source Identification.** Identify an alternative mathematical framework containing specific algebraic or structural claims amenable to formalization. The framework must make assertions beyond rhetorical or philosophical claims.
2. **Claim Extraction.** Enumerate all formalizable assertions from the source material. Separate mathematical claims ("$j^4 = 1$") from rhetoric ("electricity is fundamental"), physics claims ("aether exists"), and philosophical framing. Document the extraction process, including claims deliberately excluded and why.

3. **Translation.** Map each extracted claim to dependent type theory. Document all translation choices, especially where source notation is ambiguous. When multiple interpretations exist, formalize the most charitable one (*principle of charity*).
4. **Verification Attempt.** For each translated claim, attempt proof or disproof using standard tactics. Record the outcome: proved, disproved (with counterexample or contradiction), or neither (claim may be ambiguous or unformalizable).
5. **Taxonomy Classification.** Assign each claim to one of five categories (Section 5).
6. **Neutral Reporting.** Present all results without editorial judgment on the source framework. The role of the formal verifier is analogous to that of an auditor: to report findings, not to advocate or condemn.

4 Case Study: Dollard's Versor Algebra

4.1 Background

Eric Dollard is an independent researcher in electrical engineering who has proposed a "versor algebra" as an extension of standard complex-number methods for analyzing polyphase power systems [15] and transmission lines [18,19]. The framework introduces three operators: j (the standard imaginary unit), h (a proposed "hyperbolic" operator with $h^2 = 1$, $h^1 = -1$), and $k = hj$ (a "sequence" operator). Dollard claims these operators form a novel algebraic structure with applications to electromagnetic theory.

The source materials are four self-published documents: *Lone Pine Writings*, *Four Quadrant Theory*, *Versor Algebra*, and *Advanced Versor Algebra II-23* [18,19]. These documents are not peer-reviewed and are not widely available; we therefore reproduce the core definitions here for self-containment. We extracted 17 formalizable claims from these sources.

Dollard's axioms. Dollard postulates three operators j, h, k in a unital associative algebra, subject to five stated properties:

(A1) $j^2 = -1$ (the standard imaginary unit),
(A2) $hj = k$ (product definition of the sequence operator),
(A3) $jk = 1$ (cancellation),
(A4) $h^1 = -1$ (h evaluates to -1),
(A5) $h^2 = 1$ (h squared is unity).

Dollard writes $h = \sqrt{+1}^{1/2}$, using both the square root and a fractional exponent, which is mathematically ambiguous (see Section 4.4). The intended interpretation appears to be an operator that squares to $+1$ but is itself -1—distinct from the principal square root.

Sign convention. A critical detail: Dollard uses the admittance convention $Y = G - jB$ (negative susceptance), not the standard $Y = G + jB$. This affects the telegraph equation expansion. Our formalization verifies both conventions for comparison.

4.2 Verified: $\mathbb{Z}_4$ Cyclic Group Structure

Dollard's operators $\{1, j, h, k\}$ with $j^2 = -1$, $h = -1$, $k = hj = -j$, and $jk = 1$ form a group under multiplication. These operators coincide with the 4th roots of unity $\{1, i, -1, -i\}$ under complex multiplication.

Listing 1.1. Versor operators as 4th roots of unity (excerpt from `basic_operators.lean`)

```
def j : ℂ:= Complex.I
def h : ℂ:= -1
def k : ℂ:= h * j

theorem j_fourth_power : j ^ 4 = 1 := by ...
theorem h_squared : h ^ 2 = 1 := by ...
theorem jk_cancellation : j * k = 1 := by ...
```

Key products of the multiplication table are verified. The structure is trivially correct—it is standard complex arithmetic. The verification confirms Dollard's framework includes correct standard results, though the algebraic content is not novel.

4.3 Disproved: Versor Form Equivalence

Dollard claims that the telegraph equation product $ZY = (R + jX)(G - jB)$ can be equivalently written in "versor form" as:

$$ZY = h(XB + RG) + j(XG - RB)$$

With $h = -1$ (as established by the $\mathbb{Z}_4$ structure):

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Versor:} \quad & h(XB{+}RG) + j(XG{-}RB) = -(XB{+}RG) + j(XG{-}RB) \\ \text{Telegraph:} \quad & (RG{+}XB) + j(XG{-}RB) \end{aligned}$$

The imaginary parts match, but the real parts differ by sign. The forms are equal only when $RG + XB = 0$—a degenerate case where both dissipation and storage vanish simultaneously.

Listing 1.2. Versor form disproof (excerpt from `telegraph_equation.lean`)

```
theorem versor_form_value (R X G B : ℝ) :
   h * (↑(factor_XB X B + factor_RG R G) : ℂ) +
   j * (↑(factor_XG X G - factor_RB R B) : ℂ) =
   Complex.mk (-(factor_XB X B + factor_RG R G))
             (factor_XG X G - factor_RB R B) := by
  simp only [h, j]
  apply Complex.ext <;> simp [...]
```

This disproof is robust: it holds regardless of sign convention (Dollard or standard), because $h = -1$ negates the real part in either case. Furthermore, the versor form is *irreparable*: we prove that the coefficient on the real part must equal 1 for equivalence (`versor_repaired_with_one`), but $h \neq 1$ (`h_ne_one`).

4.4 Algebraic Necessity: $h = -1$ Forced

The most structurally interesting result: Dollard's three core axioms $j^2 = -1$, $hj = k$, $jk = 1$ *alone* force $h = -1$ over any field. The proof is elementary:

$$jk = 1 \implies k = j^{-1} = -j, \qquad hj = k = -j \implies h = -1$$

The axioms $h^1 = -1$ and $h^2 = 1$ are redundant—they follow from the three core axioms. This means Dollard's algebra has zero degrees of freedom: any unital associative algebra satisfying the core axioms is forced to $\mathbb{Z}_4$.

Listing 1.3. Algebraic necessity over any field (excerpt from `algebraic_necessity.lean`)

```
-- Section variables: {F : Type*} [Field F] {j' h' k' : F}
theorem algebraic_necessity_general
    (hj2 : j' ^ 2 = -1) (hhj : h' * j' = k')
    (hjk : j' * k' = 1) :
    h' = -1 := by ...
```

This result closes the "rehabilitation question": to obtain a non-trivial h (e.g., in $\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$ where $e_1^2 = 1$ but $e_1 \neq \pm 1$), one must drop at least two of Dollard's three core axioms. The resulting algebra is a *different* system, not a repair of Dollard's.

The D_8 alternative. In the standard Clifford-algebraic sense, versors satisfy anticommutativity: in $\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$, generators e_1, e_2 with $e_1^2 = +1$, $e_2^2 = -1$ satisfy $e_1 e_2 = -e_2 e_1$. Identifying $h = e_1$ and $j = e_2$, the group generated by $\{j, h\}$ has 8 elements $\{\pm 1, \pm j, \pm h, \pm jh\}$ and is isomorphic to the dihedral group D_8. Our algebraic necessity result confirms this from the complementary direction: Dollard's (implicit) commutativity assumption forces $h = -1$, collapsing D_8 to $\mathbb{Z}_4$. The sign error identified in Section 4.3 is a direct consequence of this collapse—had Dollard worked in $\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$ with anticommuting generators, the versor form would require different algebraic treatment entirely.

4.5 Ambiguous: Notation Issues

Dollard writes $h = \sqrt{+1}^{1/2}$, which is mathematically ambiguous. In $\mathbb{R}$, $\sqrt{1} = 1$ and $1^{1/2} = 1$, so $h = 1$—but Dollard claims $h = -1$. The notation admits multiple interpretations, none of which are standard.

The algebraic necessity result makes this ambiguity irrelevant: rather than resolving it by fiat, we show that (Section 4.4) makes the notation irrelevant. Whatever $\sqrt{+1}^{1/2}$ means, h must equal -1 in any algebra satisfying Dollard's core axioms.

4.6 Unfalsifiable: Physics Claims

Dollard defines Ψ (total dielectric induction, in Coulombs) and Φ (total magnetic induction, in Webers), with $Q = \Psi \cdot \Phi$ and $W = dQ/dt$. Dimensionally, Coulomb $\times$ Weber $=$ J $\cdot$ s (action), making Q the action and W the energy. Primary source analysis suggests a connection to Lagrangian circuit theory: Dollard's $d\Psi/dt = I$ (current) and $d\Phi/dt = E$ (voltage) correspond to the Lagrangian circuit variables where charge q is the generalized coordinate and flux λ is the conjugate momentum. The dimensional analysis is verified in Lean 4 (`circuit_action.lean`, 0 `sorry`); the Lagrangian identification itself is an interpretive observation, not a formal result. The framework is dimensionally correct but not novel—it is Lagrangian circuit theory, known since Cherry [20].

Several remaining claims—"electricity is fundamental," "aether exists as a fifth state of matter," "$W = dQ/dt$ replaces $E = mc^2$"—are not addressable by formal mathematical methods. We classify these as Unfalsifiable (by theorem provers), noting that this classification is itself a useful result: it separates the checkable from the uncheckable.

5 A Taxonomy for Claims from Alternative Frameworks

Based on the case study, we propose a five-category taxonomy for classifying claims from alternative mathematical frameworks:

Table 1. Five-category taxonomy for claims from alternative frameworks

Category	Definition	Example
Verified	Claim is mathematically correct; formal proof produced	$\mathbb{Z}_4$ group structure
Disproved	Claim is mathematically false; formal counterexample or contradiction produced	Versor form equivalence
Algebraic Necessity	Premises force a conclusion the author did not intend	$h = -1$ forced by core axioms
Ambiguous	Claim cannot be formalized without resolving notation/definition gaps	$h = \sqrt{+1}^{1/2}$
Unfalsifiable	Claim is not addressable by formal methods	Physics/empirical claims

Mixed results across these categories are the *expected* and methodologically interesting case. Uniform rejection would suggest the framework is too incoherent to formalize. Uniform verification would suggest the framework is merely standard mathematics with non-standard notation. The mixed outcome—some

verified, some disproved, some ambiguous—reveals genuine structure worth analyzing, and shows that formal methods can distinguish valid from invalid claims within a single framework.

The Algebraic Necessity category merits special attention. It captures cases where the author's axioms entail consequences they did not recognize or intend. This phenomenon has precedents across several fields: as a consequence of Hilbert's implicit definitions (the Frege-Hilbert controversy), as "implicit commitment" in epistemic logic [22], and as overspecification in formal methods. The Banach-Tarski paradox is a canonical example at larger scale—the axiom of choice forces consequences its adopters did not foresee.

We note a duality with Lakatos's *Proofs and Refutations* [21]: Lakatos addresses axiom systems that are too *weak*, admitting unintended models ("monsters" requiring barring). Our Algebraic Necessity addresses axiom systems that are too *strong*, forcing unintended consequences. These are dual failure modes:

Failure	**Direction**	**Lakatos**	**This work**
Axioms too weak	Admit unintended models	Monster-barring	—
Axioms too strong	Force unintended conclusions	—	Alg. Necessity

This duality suggests that Algebraic Necessity fills a genuine gap in the vocabulary for analyzing axiom systems—particularly relevant when formal methods are applied to frameworks whose authors may not have fully explored the consequences of their axioms.

6 The Clifford Algebra Hierarchy

Beyond classification, formal methods can suggest *corrections*. We formalize four Clifford algebras of increasing dimension, each independently verified in Lean 4:

Table 2. Clifford algebras formalized in Lean 4 (independently defined, no connecting morphisms)

Level	**Algebra**	**Dim**	**Physical Content**
1	$\mathbb{Z}_4$	4	Versor operators (trivial, forced by axioms)
2	$\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$	4	Idempotent wave decomposition
3	$\mathrm{Cl}(3,0)$	8	Pauli algebra; $F = E + IB$
4	$\mathrm{Cl}(1,3)$	16	Spacetime algebra; $\nabla F = J$

Each level is formalized in Lean 4 with zero `sorry` gaps.

At Level 2, $\mathrm{Cl}(1,1)$ provides what Dollard was reaching for: an operator e_1 with $e_1^2 = +1$ that is distinct from ± 1 by construction (it occupies a different basis component). However, this algebra is non-commutative ($e_1 e_2 \neq e_2 e_1$), and

Dollard's axiom $jk = 1$ fails ($e_2 \cdot e_{12} = e_1 \neq 1$). The algebra offers idempotent projectors $P_\pm = \frac{1 \pm e_1}{2}$ that decompose signals into forward and backward wave components—a genuine mathematical tool for transmission line analysis.

At Level 4, $\mathrm{Cl}(1,3)$ is the spacetime algebra [16,17] in which Maxwell's equations take the compact form $\nabla F = J$. The Lean 4 formalization verifies the algebraic structure (signature, bivector decomposition, Lorentz boost action) but not the differential equation itself, which requires smooth manifold infrastructure not available in our formalization.

Dollard's *instinct*—algebraic unification of electromagnetic phenomena—was correct, while his *execution*—a commutative group with four elements—was far too restrictive. The Clifford algebras provide the correct mathematical setting.

7 Discussion

7.1 Why Mixed Results Matter

The case study produced all five taxonomy categories across 17 claims. This distribution validates the protocol's discriminating power: it is neither a rubber stamp nor a blanket dismissal.

The sign error in the versor form (Section 4.3) could have been noticed by informal calculation, but Lean provides machine-checked certainty that the error is irreparable—a stronger conclusion than informal reasoning alone supports.

7.2 Why the Gap Exists

The four structural factors identified in Section 1—cultural separation, no academic incentive, asymmetric difficulty, no client—explain why this application domain has been overlooked. We note that none of these factors are *mathematical*; the gap is sociological. The mathematical tools are entirely adequate: standard Lean 4 tactics suffice for all proofs in our case study, and no custom tactics or library extensions were required.

7.3 The Constructive Dimension

The Clifford algebra formalizations (Section 6) suggest the correct mathematical framework for Dollard's aspirations. Showing not just what is wrong but what the author *should* have said is a constructive application of formal methods to alternative frameworks.

7.4 Limitations

Our protocol is demonstrated on a single case study; generalizability to other alternative frameworks is conjectured but not proven. Dollard's source materials are self-published presentations, not peer-reviewed papers, introducing translation ambiguities that are inherent to the domain. All Lean 4 proofs compile against mathlib (the full 59-file repository builds with zero errors, zero `sorry` gaps). We formalize algebraic and structural claims only; we make no claims about the physics, engineering utility, or broader validity of Dollard's work.

8 Conclusion

We have demonstrated that interactive theorem provers can be productively applied to claims from alternative mathematical frameworks. The protocol produces mixed results—verified, disproved, algebraically necessary, ambiguous, and unfalsifiable—that reveal genuine mathematical structure. The five-category taxonomy provides a systematic classification scheme. The Clifford algebra formalizations show that formal methods can constructively suggest the "correct" version of an alternative framework's aspirations.

Formal methods separate what is mathematically checkable from what is not, what is correct from what is wrong, and what is novel from what is standard. We call for further case studies on other alternative mathematical frameworks to validate and refine the protocol.

Source code, source materials, and analysis documents are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Appendix: Complete Claim Summary

Table 3. All 17 formalized claims with taxonomy classification

#	Claim	Category	Proof File
1	$\{1, j, h, k\}$ as 4th roots of unity	VERIFIED	`basic_operators`
2	Telegraph expansion $(R + jX)(G - jB)$	VERIFIED	`telegraph_equation`
3	Four-factor independence	DISPROVED*	`telegraph_equation`
4	Versor form equivalence	DISPROVED	`telegraph_equation`
5	Universal polyphase formula	VERIFIED	`polyphase_formula`
6	$h = \sqrt{+1}^{1/2}$ notation	AMBIGUOUS	`algebraic_necessity`
7	Sequence periodicity	VERIFIED	`basic_operators`
8	$Q = \Psi \cdot \Phi$ (action)	VERIFIED†	`circuit_action`
9	Electricity as fundamental	UNFALSIFIABLE	—
10	Aether as 5th state	UNFALSIFIABLE	—
11	$W = dQ/dt$ replaces $E = mc^2$	UNFALSIFIABLE	—
12	Over-unity energy	UNFALSIFIABLE	—
13	Dielectric counterspace	UNFALSIFIABLE	—
14	Quaternary expansion	VERIFIED‡	(computational)
15	Fortescue is domain-specific	VERIFIED	(empirical)
16	A_4 matches versor matrix	VERIFIED	(computational)
17	$jk = 1$ forces $h = -1$	ALG. NECESSITY	`algebraic_necessity`

*Four terms exist but satisfy $(RG)(XB) = (XG)(RB)$; not independent.
†Dimensionally correct (Weber·Coulomb = J·s) but not novel (Cherry, 1951).
‡Mathematically correct but practically useless (deprecated).

Note on mathlib. Mathlib includes a comprehensive formalization of Clifford algebras (`Mathlib.LinearAlgebra.CliffordAlgebra`) [10] with grading, spin groups, and conjugation. Our case study uses explicit finite-dimensional representations for pedagogical clarity, but a natural extension would unify our ad-hoc $\mathrm{Cl}(p, q)$ types with mathlib's abstract `CliffordAlgebra` via isomorphism proofs. As a step in this direction, four Lie algebras in the extended repository—so(1,3), sl(3), sl(5), and so(10)—now carry certified `LieRing` and `LieAlgebra` $\mathbb{R}$ instances via `Mathlib.Algebra.Lie.Basic`, connecting the explicit constructions to mathlib's abstract type system.

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